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The Thinking System

A repeatable method for choosing moves

THE PROMISE

Replace impulsive move selection with a compact process that survives real clock pressure.

VOLUME 02 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Read the position before generating moves.
- Generate a small candidate set and test the opponent's best reply.
- Finish with a blunder scan that is fast enough to use every move.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

Start with the position, not a move

Before calculating, describe what is true now. Count material, compare king safety, note immediate threats, identify loose pieces, and find the pawn breaks that could change the structure. This ten-second scan prevents a familiar plan from being applied to the wrong position.

Position cues

- Material: what is the exact balance and which exchanges favor whom?
- Kings: whose shelter is weaker and can lines open quickly?
- Pieces: which are loose, pinned, overloaded, or badly placed?
- Pawns: what breaks and passed pawns exist?
- Urgency: what changed on the opponent's last move?

PRACTICE RULE

Say one sentence: 'The position is about...' If you cannot, list two competing explanations and let calculation decide.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not perform a complete strategic essay every move. The scan is a filter; spend time only when the position changed materially.

Generate candidates by function

A candidate list should cover tactical force, defensive necessity, and positional improvement. Usually two to four candidates are enough. Listing ten moves is avoidance; calculating the first attractive move is impulse.

Position cues

- Forcing candidate: check, capture, direct threat, or tactical break.
- Necessary candidate: answer a threat or repair a tactical defect.
- Improving candidate: activate the worst piece or prepare a pawn break.
- Restricting candidate: stop the opponent's best plan.

PRACTICE RULE

Write candidates before analyzing any one deeply. Give each a short label such as 'win tempo,' 'trade attacker,' or 'open c-file.'

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Checks are not automatically calculated first. A useless check can help the enemy king improve; urgency and promise determine order.

Calculate the opponent's best resistance

After choosing a candidate, switch sides mentally. Look for the opponent's forcing reply, strongest defensive resource, and most annoying intermediate move. Good calculation is adversarial: it tries to refute your idea.

Position cues

- After my move, what checks does the opponent gain?
- What can be captured, including the piece I just moved away from?
- Can the opponent ignore my threat and create a larger one?
- Is there an in-between move before the expected recapture?

PRACTICE RULE

Use the phrase 'and then what?' until the position becomes quiet enough to evaluate. At the leaf, compare material, king safety, activity, and structure.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Never stop a line because your intended move looks strong. Stop when the opponent's best reply has been answered.

Compare outcomes, not first moves

Two candidates may look different but lead to related positions. Compare the resulting positions using the same criteria. A tactical gain that leaves your king exposed may be worse than a quiet move that wins later without risk.

Position cues

- What is the material balance at the end of the line?
- Which pieces remain and whose pieces are more active?
- Whose king is safer after exchanges?
- Is the advantage stable or does it require continued precision?

PRACTICE RULE

State a verdict for each candidate: favorable, unclear, or unfavorable, plus the reason. Choose the move whose downside you understand.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not compare one deeply calculated line with a vague impression of another. Give serious candidates comparable attention.

The five-second blunder shield

Immediately before playing, reset your eyes. Confirm the destination square, scan every enemy check and capture created by your move, and inspect undefended pieces. This is not more calculation; it is quality control.

Position cues

- Destination: can the moved piece be captured?
- Departure: what line or piece did it stop defending?
- King: did the move expose a check, pin, or back-rank problem?
- Opponent: what is their simplest forcing reply?

PRACTICE RULE

Make the scan identical on every move so it becomes automatic. In low time, shorten calculation before deleting the blunder shield.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not use the shield to reopen the entire decision. It catches one-move defects; it is not an invitation to panic.

Match depth to the position

Think longer when moves are forcing, the structure may change, kings are exposed, or the decision is irreversible. Think faster in stable positions where several moves preserve the same plan.

Position cues

- Critical: captures, pawn breaks, sacrifices, queen trades, and king moves.
- Stable: routine recaptures, forced replies, and harmless improving moves.
- Complex: many forcing branches or a large gap between best and second-best move.
- Practical: choose a safe move when exact calculation is impossible and risk is asymmetric.

PRACTICE RULE

Ask, 'If I get this decision wrong, how hard is it to recover?' Spend time according to consequence and complexity.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

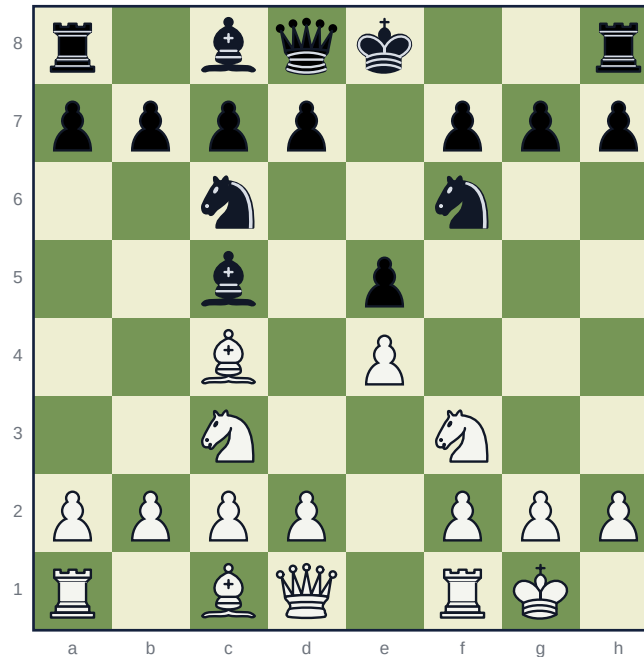
Using equal time on every move wastes the clock before the positions that deserve it.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

White to move. Do not search for a named opening move. List one forcing, one improving, and one restricting candidate, then state what the position is about.



Italian-type development position

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

Your intended move wins a pawn, but it removes the only defender of your back rank. Where in the thinking system should this be caught?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

The point is candidate diversity. White has a lead in castling and can consider d3, Re1, and moves that exploit Black's uncastled king. There is no need to force tactics if they are not sound; the useful conclusion is that development and central control govern the decision.

LAB 02

It may appear during opponent-resistance calculation, but it must be caught by the departure-square item in the final blunder shield. The key question is not only where the piece lands, but what its movement stops protecting.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- What changed on the last move?
- What is the position about?
- List 2-4 candidates by function.
- Test the opponent's best forcing reply.
- Evaluate the final position.
- Run the destination-departure blunder shield.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

01_Tactical_Patterns.pdf

Personal notes
